

“The **exhilaration of flying** is too keen, the pleasure too great, for it to be **neglected as a sport.**”

ORVILLE WRIGHT (1871-1948)

emerged, with the United States catching up and then overtaking Europe with all-metal, retractable-undercarriage monoplanes that would ensure its dominance until the 1990s. In the same era, racing and record-breaking aircraft took speeds up to more than 400 mph (644 km/h), crossed the Atlantic, and took the world altitude record to nearly 60,000 ft (18,288 m). In Britain, de Havilland introduced the private aircraft in the form of the economical Gipsy Moth, and in the United States William Piper made it affordable with the immortal Cub. The helicopter emerged alongside the first jet engines in the 1940s, and the jet airliner became a reality a decade later. The light airplane appeared in its modern form as the all-metal, high-wing Cessna 170/172, and Piper followed suit in 1960, with the low-wing PA-28 Cherokee—designs so good that they are still in production.

Not every advance has been for the best. Military aircraft, once stuttering things with shimmering propellers that weaved over battlefields like gadflies, were made into ever-more-effective killing machines during the two world wars, culminating in the B-29 bombers that were used to drop the atomic bombs on Japan. The drive for military superiority produced aircraft that flew much faster than the speed of sound, and the same imperative has given us the stealth bomber and unmanned aircraft that, operating from homeland bases, are used to monitor and attack assumed enemies thousands of miles away.

Today, there are more ways to fly—more ways to travel and more ways to let your imagination take wing—than ever before. We travel routinely to the farthest corners of the globe by business jets and airliners, and, in places that once had no access by air, helicopters can land. Adventurers and private pilots can become airborne in anything from ultralights to twin-engine, very light jets, with a vast range of homebuilt, classic, and light sport aircraft in between. If you want to experience the joy of piloting open-cockpit biplanes, they are there for the flying. If you relish the sport of riding invisible air currents and staying aloft without engine power, there are sailplanes that can race hundreds of miles in a day. If you can afford to explore the world, there are high-flying single-engine turboprops that will carry you nonstop from Northern Europe to North Africa or halfway across North America without refueling.

All these aircraft require power to operate, and we know that the world's oil resources are ever-diminishing. However, the great human power of invention that gave us the aircraft in all its forms is now being harnessed to produce superlight structures and alternative-energy power units—certain bets, I believe, for keeping alive the magic and adventure of flight for generations to come.

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